PIHOCO

SAMPLE · FICTIONAL DATA

MENU PROFIT BOOST AUDIT

What your menu is *really earning.*

PREPARED FOR

Larkspur

A 64-cover neighbourhood bistro, clerkenwell, london

SALES PERIOD

1 Sep – 26 Oct 2026

6,160 items · 2,800 covers

REVIEWED & SIGNED OFF BY

Piyush Raikwar

Founder, PIHOCO · issued 9 Nov 2026

Larkspur is a fictional venue. Every figure in this sample is invented and internally consistent, so you can follow the method end to end. A real audit uses only the exports you send us.

CONTENTS

01 Summary
02 Sales mix vs contribution
03 The matrix, by section
04 Dish data
05 Pricing
06 Kitchen load
07 Action plan
08 Impact model
09 Method, data & next steps

THE HEADLINE

Your menu is busy. *It isn't earning in the right places.*

Three popular mains carry 73% of main-course sales but only 65% of main-course contribution. The dishes that earn most per plate are the ones guests aren't finding.

NET FOOD REVENUE
£8,124
per week, ex VAT

FOOD COST
32.2%
of net revenue, plate cost only

CONTRIBUTION PER ITEM
£7.15
weighted average, all sections

OPPORTUNITY FOUND
£4.3k–11.2k
a year in contribution, across 3 scenarios

WHAT WE FOUND

1 **Your best earners are hidden.** 4 dishes earn above their section's average contribution but sit below the popularity line. Braised Lamb Shoulder leaves £14.07 a plate, £4.82 more than the average main, yet is chosen by 1 in 9 main-course guests.

2 **Popular dishes are under-priced, not over-costed.** Caesar Salad would need to lose 11% of its sales before a £1.00 increase cost you money. Its food cost is already 29%.

3 **Two plates cost more kitchen time than they return.** Pork Belly Bao and Short Rib Croquettes earn under £0.55 per kitchen minute against a menu average of £1.39. Between them they take 7.6 hours of fry-station time a week.

4 **Don't cut on the matrix alone.** Lemon Posset is classed a Dog, but earns the most per kitchen minute on the menu (£2.62). It needs a better place on the page, not the bin.

WHAT WE RECOMMEND, IN ORDER

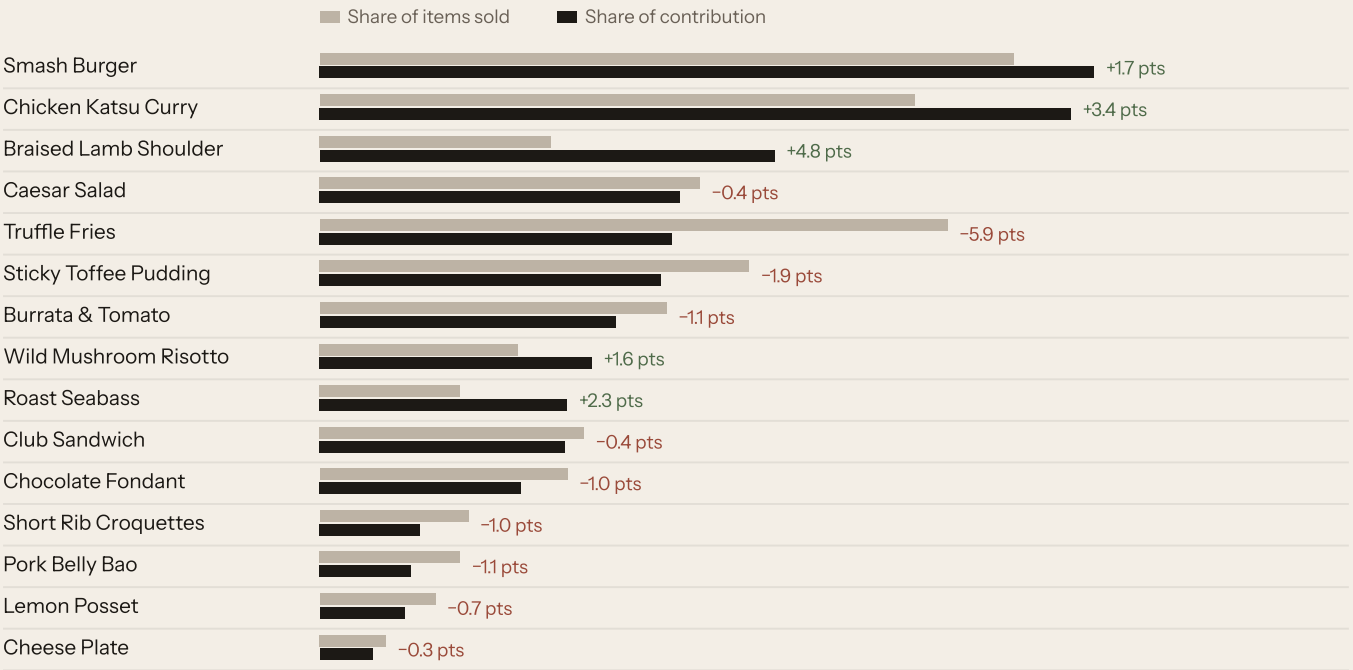
#	DECISION	£ / WEEK
1	**Braised Lamb Shoulder** Box it, move it to the top of mains, brief the floor	+£52
2	**Caesar Salad** Reprice £11.50 → £12.50	+£29
3	**Truffle Fries** Portion 180g → 150g; offer with the burger	+£26
4	**Roast Seabass** Simplify garnish (5 elements → 3), then feature	+£33
5	**Pork Belly Bao** Retire; free the fry station	+£22
6	**Short Rib Croquettes** Move to weekend specials only	+£3
	Expected, all six	**+£165**

Expected case. At the founding rate (about £590), the audit pays back in roughly 4 weeks; in 7 weeks in the conservative case. Assumptions are on page 09.

02 · SALES MIX VS CONTRIBUTION

What sells is not *what pays.*

Every dish, ranked by the cash it left after food cost over the period. Where the dark bar is longer than the grey, a dish earns more than its share of orders suggests.



CONCENTRATION

Your three best sellers, Smash Burger, Truffle Fries, Chicken Katsu Curry, are 41% of items sold and 41% of contribution.

BIGGEST GAP

Truffle Fries are 13.6% of everything sold but 7.6% of contribution. Volume is fine; the plate cost is the lever.

READ WITH CARE

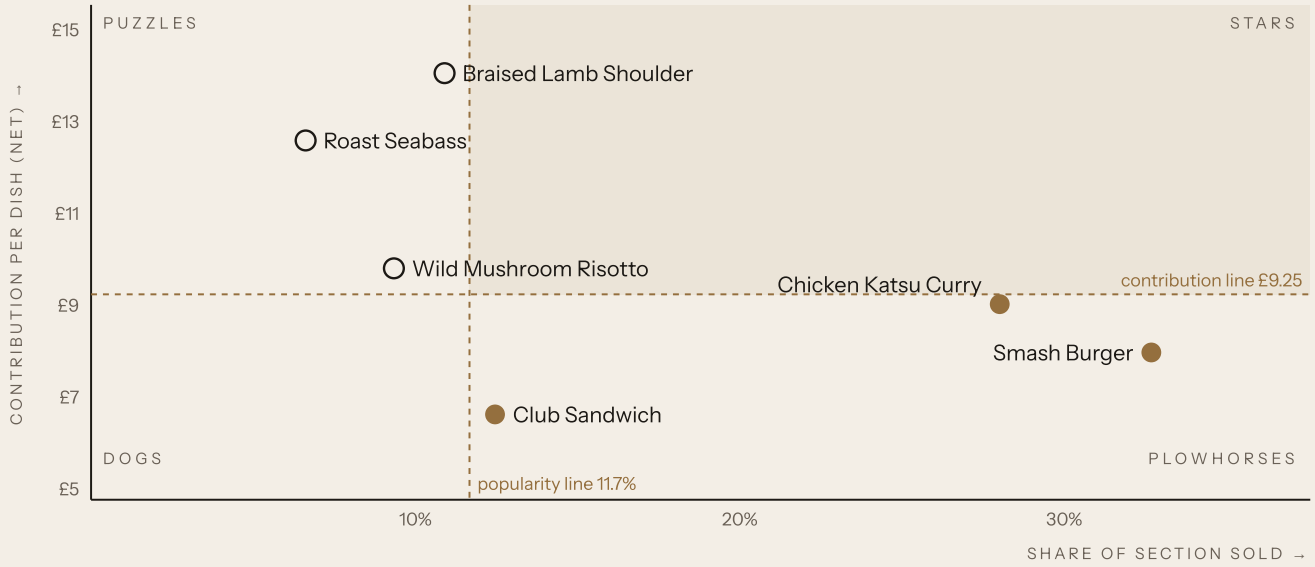
Mains earn more per plate by design. That's why the matrix on the next page compares each dish only with its own section.

03 · THE MATRIX, BY SECTION

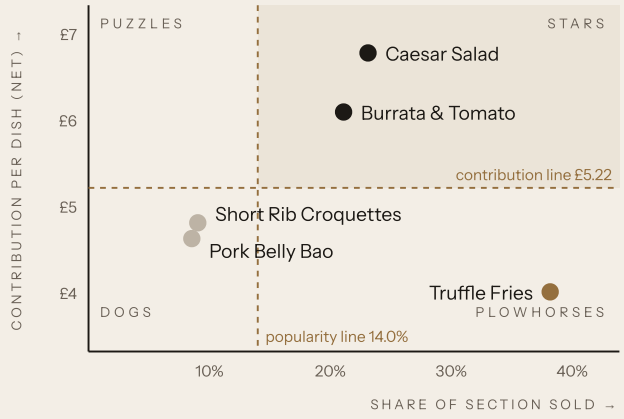
Four kinds of dish. *Four decisions.*

Popularity is a dish's share of its section. Contribution is net price less plate cost. Lines sit at 70% of an equal share and the section's weighted average contribution (Kasavana & Smith).

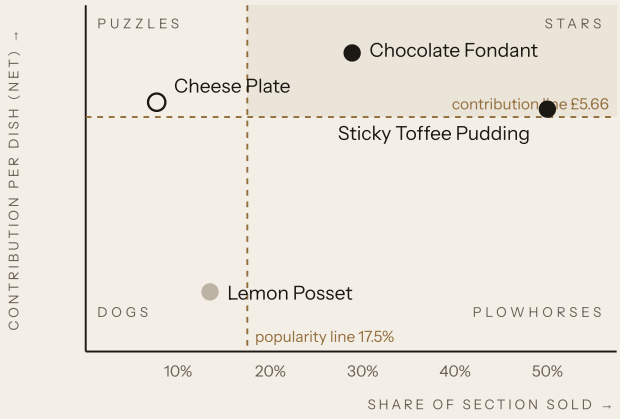
MAINS · 2,827 SOLD



SMALL PLATES · 2,189 SOLD



DESSERTS · 1,144 SOLD



● Star
Popular and profitable. Protect the spec and the position.

● Plowhorse
Popular, thin margin. Re-cost, re-portion or reprice.

○ Puzzle
Profitable, overlooked. Reposition and recommend.

● Dog
Low on both. Rework or retire, unless it's strategic.

04 · DISH DATA

Every dish, *on one page.*

Built from your item sales export and the recipe costings agreed with your head chef. Your Excel model has the same table, live, so you can test a price before you print it.

DISH	SOLD	MIX	MENU PRICE	NET OF VAT	PLATE COST	FOOD COST	CONTRIBUTION	TOTAL CONTRIB.	CLASS
Caesar Salad	506	23.1%	£11.50	£9.58	£2.80	29.2%	£6.78	£3,432	● Star
Truffle Fries	836	38.2%	£6.50	£5.42	£1.40	25.8%	£4.02	£3,358	● Plowhorse
Burrata & Tomato	462	21.1%	£12.00	£10.00	£3.90	39.0%	£6.10	£2,818	● Star
Short Rib Croquettes	198	9.0%	£9.50	£7.92	£3.10	39.2%	£4.82	£954	● Dog
Pork Belly Bao	187	8.5%	£10.00	£8.33	£3.70	44.4%	£4.63	£866	● Dog
Small plates	**2,189**	**100%**		**£17,123**		**33.3%**	**£5.22**	**£11,429**	
Smash Burger	924	32.7%	£14.50	£12.08	£4.10	33.9%	£7.98	£7,377	● Plowhorse
Chicken Katsu Curry	792	28.0%	£16.00	£13.33	£4.30	32.2%	£9.03	£7,154	● Plowhorse
Braised Lamb Shoulder	308	10.9%	£26.00	£21.67	£7.60	35.1%	£14.07	£4,333	○ Puzzle
Wild Mushroom Risotto	264	9.3%	£15.50	£12.92	£3.10	24.0%	£9.82	£2,592	○ Puzzle
Roast Seabass	187	6.6%	£24.00	£20.00	£7.40	37.0%	£12.60	£2,356	○ Puzzle
Club Sandwich	352	12.5%	£13.00	£10.83	£4.20	38.8%	£6.63	£2,335	● Plowhorse
Mains	**2,827**	**100%**		**£39,362**		**33.6%**	**£9.25**	**£26,146**	
Sticky Toffee Pudding	572	50.0%	£8.50	£7.08	£1.40	19.8%	£5.68	£3,251	● Star
Chocolate Fondant	330	28.8%	£9.50	£7.92	£2.10	26.5%	£5.82	£1,920	● Star
Lemon Posset	154	13.5%	£7.50	£6.25	£1.00	16.0%	£5.25	£808	● Dog
Cheese Plate	88	7.7%	£12.00	£10.00	£4.30	43.0%	£5.70	£502	○ Puzzle
Desserts	**1,144**	**100%**		**£8,507**		**23.8%**	**£5.66**	**£6,480**	
All sections	**6,160**			**£64,992**	**£20,936**	**32.2%**	**£7.15**	**£44,055**	

Net of VAT. Menu prices include 20% VAT, which isn't yours to keep. Contribution is worked from the net price (menu price ÷ 1.20).

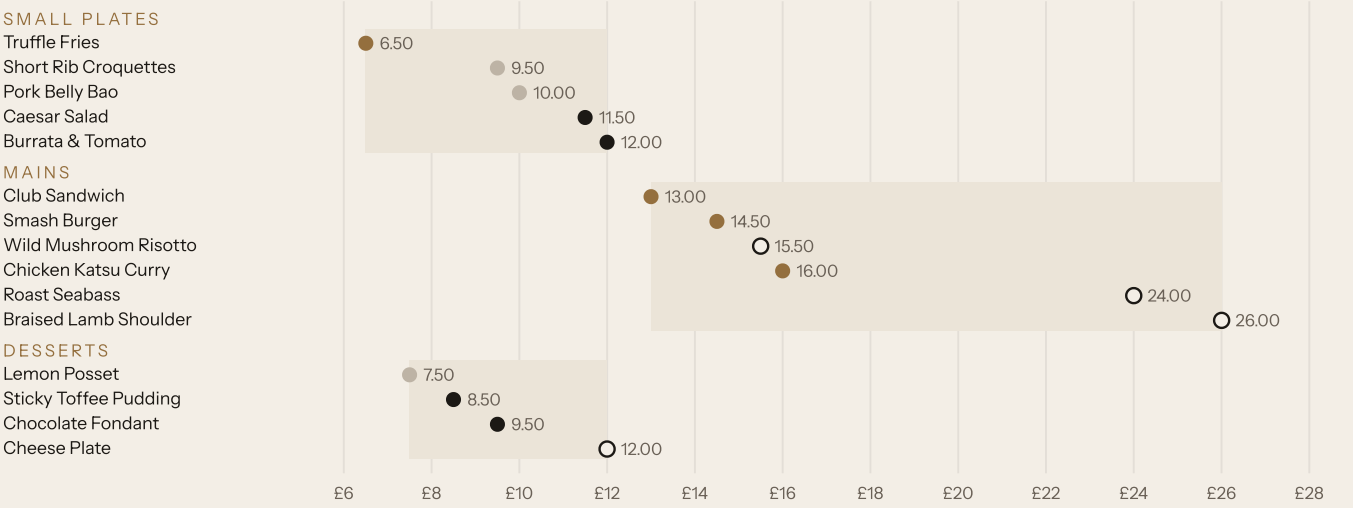
Plate cost. Ingredients as plated, including garnish, sauce and a 3% waste allowance; priced from September supplier invoices.

Red food cost marks anything above 38%. It's a flag, not a verdict: Braised Lamb runs 35% and is still the best earner per plate.

05 · PRICING

Where a price can move, *and how far.*

How your prices sit within each section, and how many sales a dish could lose after a rise before it earned you less. Guests compare dishes within a section, not across the menu.



BREAK-EVEN TEST · HOW MUCH VOLUME A PRICE RISE CAN LOSE BEFORE IT COSTS YOU

DISH	CLASS	PRICE NOW	SOLD / WEEK	BREAK-EVEN AT + £0.50	BREAK-EVEN AT + £1.00	£/WK AT +£1.00, 5% FEWER SOLD
Caesar Salad	● Star	£11.50	63	5.8%	10.9%	+£29
Smash Burger	● Plowhorse	£14.50	116	5.0%	9.5%	+£45
Chicken Katsu Curry	● Plowhorse	£16.00	99	4.4%	8.4%	+£34
Sticky Toffee Pudding	● Star	£8.50	72	6.8%	12.8%	+£36
Burrata & Tomato	● Star	£12.00	58	6.4%	12.0%	+£28

Break-even volume loss = net price increase ÷ (contribution + net price increase). In our experience, a well-presented rise of under 8% on a popular dish rarely loses more than 3–5% of its sales; we test this on your menu rather than assume it.

The mains ladder has a hole. Nothing sits between £16.00 and £24.00. Guests trading up from the burger meet an £8 jump. A main around £19–20 would catch them.

Small plates bunch at £9.50–£12.00. With four prices inside £2.50, guests pick on description. At £12.50, Caesar would still sit only 50p above the burrata.

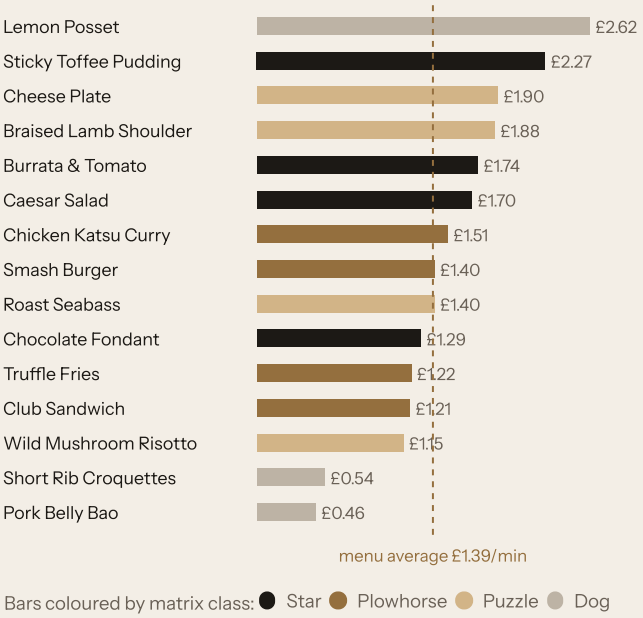
Remove the £ signs and trailing zeros. Print "12.5", not "£12.50", and let the description finish the line. Prices aligned in a column invite guests to shop by price.

06 · KITCHEN LOAD

What each dish asks *of the kitchen.*

A dish that earns well but jams the pass at 8:45 on a Saturday isn't earning well. We timed prep and pick-up with your head chef across two services.

CONTRIBUTION PER KITCHEN MINUTE (PREP + PICK-UP)



LOAD BY STATION

STATION	HOURS / WEEK	PASS TIME / PEAK HR	£ PER MINUTE
Fry	23.3	31 min	£1.10
Grill	11.0	19 min	£1.40
Hot	13.0	19 min	£1.49
Cold	12.2	18 min	£1.56
Pastry	6.7	9 min	£1.86

Peak = 19:00–21:00, six services a week, carrying 45% of dinner orders (from your POS timestamps).

a **Risotto is the hot section's bottleneck.** It is 35% of hot-section plates but 45% of its pick-up time: 7 minutes to finish to order. Par-cooking the base takes it to about 3.

b **The fry station carries the menu's two weakest plates.** Bao and croquettes are 19% of fry orders and 33% of its minutes.

c **Seabass slows the pass, not the station.** Five garnish elements take 6.5 minutes to plate. Three elements, same price, about 4.

07 · ACTION PLAN

Six changes, *in order.*

Ordered by value against effort. Each has an assumption we've made explicit and a number to check it against, so you'll know within four weeks whether it worked.

#	DISH	CHANGE & WHY	EFFORT	ASSUMPTION	WE'LL MEASURE	£ / WEEK
1	**Braised Lamb Shoulder** ○ Puzzle	Box it, move it to the top of mains, brief the floor. Highest contribution on the menu (£14.07) but only 10.9% of mains	LOW	+25% lamb sales (77 portions / 8 wks), taken from other mains	Lamb share of mains vs 10.9% baseline	**+£52**
2	**Caesar Salad** ● Star	Reprice £11.50 → £12.50. Second-best seller in its section; break-even volume loss is 11%	LOW	5% fewer sold at the new price	Volume and contribution, 4 weeks	**+£29**
3	**Truffle Fries** ● Plowhorse	Portion 180g → 150g; offer with the burger. Most-sold plate; £1.40 plate cost is mostly oil and truffle	LOW	Plate cost £1.40 → £1.15; volume flat	Food cost per portion; complaints log	**+£26**
4	**Roast Seabass** ○ Puzzle	Simplify garnish (5 elements → 3), then feature. Strong margin, but 6.5 min at the pass slows the hot section at peak	MEDIUM	Plate cost £7.40 → £6.80; pick 6.5 → 4.0 min; +20% sales	Ticket times 19:30–21:00; seabass share	**+£33**
5	**Pork Belly Bao** ● Dog	Retire; free the fry station. Low on both axes and 10 minutes of kitchen time per portion	LOW	60% of bao buyers choose another plate; 31 kitchen hrs freed at £14.50/hr	Small-plate sales per cover; prep hours	**+£22**
6	**Short Rib Croquettes** ● Dog	Move to weekend specials only. Labour-heavy (6 min prep each), rarely ordered midweek	LOW	55% of sales kept at weekends; 40% of the rest switch to fries; 13 kitchen hrs freed	Specials uptake; prep hours	**+£3**
	All six, expected case					**+£165**

WEEK 1

Reprice Caesar, re-portion fries, brief the floor on lamb and seabass. No reprint needed for the price; use a sticker or the digital menu.

WEEKS 2–3

Seabass garnish trial on two services. Bao off; croquettes to the weekend board. Reprint with the new layout brief.

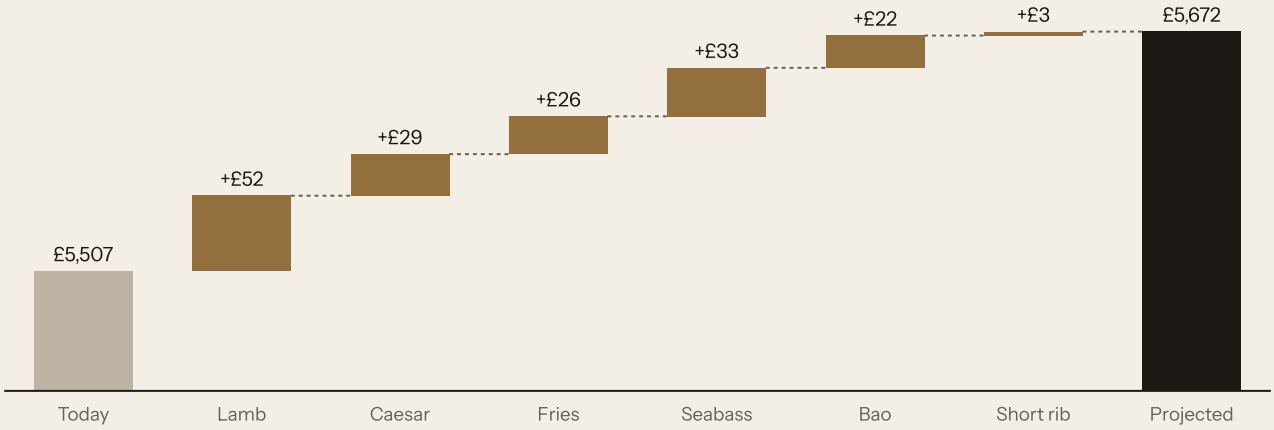
WEEK 6

30-day check: we re-run the matrix on four weeks of new sales and compare each measure with this baseline.

08 · IMPACT MODEL

From £5,507 to £5,672 *a week.*

The expected effect of each change on weekly contribution, on today's volume. No growth in covers is assumed; this is the same guests, choosing differently.



Weekly contribution, net of VAT and food cost. Axis does not start at zero.

THREE SCENARIOS

SCENARIO	REALISATION	PER WEEK	PER YEAR	LIFT ON CONTRIBUTION	AUDIT PAYBACK
Conservative	50%	+£83	+£4,293	+1.5%	7.1 wks
Expected	100%	+£165	+£8,587	+3.0%	3.6 wks
Stretch	130%	+£215	+£11,163	+3.9%	2.7 wks

WHAT COULD MAKE IT LOWER

Guests resisting the Caesar price more than the 5% assumed; the floor not recommending lamb consistently; seabass trial abandoned. The conservative case assumes only half of each effect lands.

WHAT'S NOT COUNTED

Faster ticket times at peak, a possible £19–20 main, delivery pricing, drinks and wine pairing. We leave these out rather than inflate the number. Payback uses the USD 750 founding rate, about £590.

09 · METHOD, DATA & NEXT STEPS

How we got here, *and what's yours.*

What we used

Item sales export, 1 Sep – 26 Oct 2026 · 8 weeks: 6,160 items across 2,800 covers. Recipe costings for 15 dishes, built with your head chef and priced from September invoices. Prep and pick-up times observed over two dinner services. Nothing else: no guest data, card data or POS logins.

How we analysed it

Menu engineering after Kasavana & Smith, applied section by section. Contribution on net-of-VAT price. Popularity line at 70% of an equal share. Kitchen load as contribution per minute of prep and pick-up. Price tests as break-even volume loss. Every recommendation was then checked against service reality by a chef, not just a formula.

What you keep

This report. The Excel model, with your costings and a live matrix you can update monthly. The layout brief for the reprint. A 60-minute review session with you and your head chef, and the 30-day results check.

YOUR DATA STAYS YOURS

Used for your audit. *Never for anything else.*

— Covered by an NDA, signed before you send anything.
— Never pooled with other clients' data or used as a benchmark.
— Never used to train AI models, ours or anyone else's.
— Deleted 90 days after the engagement ends. Your model and report are yours to keep.
— Never published or quoted without your written approval.

AFTER THIS REPORT

DAY 1
60-minute review with you and your head chef. We agree which of the six changes go ahead.

WEEK 1
Quick wins live: price, portion and floor briefing. No reprint needed.

WEEK 3
Layout brief to your designer; seabass and risotto changes trialled.

WEEK 6
30-day check: matrix re-run on new sales, each measure against this baseline.

SIGNED OFF

Piyush Raikwar

Founder, PIHOCO. Trained at ITC Grand Central, Mumbai; former sous chef and head of food production. Every audit is reviewed and signed by him.

NEXT STEP

Book the review session, or start with a free scorecard of your public menu: **pihoco.com** · contact@pihoco.com